INCENSE CEDAR–BRAISED RABBIT
WITH GREENS

serves 4 to 6

Incense cedar is native to California and is especially fragrant, with bright citrusy and woodsy notes. To infuse its flavor into this simple rabbit dish, I make a quick stock with it and then also add it to the braise. The combination of agave syrup and vinegar in the sauce gives it a lovely sheen.

2 whole rabbits (2½ pounds each)

STOCK

½ large onion

1 medium carrot, scrubbed well and coarsely chopped

2 wild garlic bulbs and stalks or smashed garlic cloves

2 small sprigs of fresh incense cedar or 2 tablespoons dried

BRAISE

2 tablespoons avocado oil or sunflower oil

Sea salt

2 teaspoons ground sumac

1 large yellow onion, chopped

3 wild garlic bulbs and stalks or garlic cloves, chopped

1 tablespoon agave syrup

2 small sprigs of fresh incense cedar or 1 sprig of dried

1 tablespoon cider vinegar

3 cups tender wild greens, such as lamb's quarters, amaranth greens, dandelion, or wild mustard

Finely chopped cedar (optional), for serving

Break down each rabbit into 6 serving pieces: 2 front legs, 2 hind quarters, and 2 saddle pieces. (The saddle includes both loins on either side of the spine. It can be left bone-in; cut it crosswise into two pieces. You can use a cleaver or a knife and kitchen scissors to cut the saddle in half through the spine.) Save the backbones and rib cages for the stock. Refrigerate the rabbit pieces while you make the stock.

Make the stock: In a large saucepan, combine the rabbit backbones and rib cages with 8 cups water. Bring to a boil over high heat, then reduce the heat to medium-low so the liquid barely bubbles. Skim off any scum that rises to the surface during the first 10 minutes of simmering.

Add the onion half, carrot, garlic, and incense cedar and simmer gently for about 1 hour, until the liquid is infused with the flavors.

Strain through a fine-mesh sieve into a large bowl, discarding the solids.

Make the braise: In a large, heavy pot, heat the oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Season the reserved rabbit pieces with salt and the sumac. Working in batches to avoid overcrowding, cook the rabbit for 10 minutes, turning frequently, until well browned all over (but not cooked through). Transfer to a plate.

Reduce the heat under the pot to medium. Add the chopped onion and garlic and cook for about 5 minutes, or until the onion is softened.

Add the strained stock and agave syrup and bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low, return all the browned rabbit pieces to the pot, and add the sprigs of cedar. Cover the pot and cook for about 1 hour, or until the rabbit is tender but not falling off the bone. Discard the cedar. Using tongs, transfer the rabbit pieces to a large bowl.

Bring the liquid left in the pot to a boil and cook for 15 to 20 minutes, until it is reduced to about 1½ cups. Stir in the vinegar. Add the greens and cook until just wilted, about 1 minute.

Return the rabbit to the pot just to warm through. If desired, sprinkle with some finely chopped cedar before serving.